



Neighbours **CHINA**

a painting on one of the walls show a very orderly but colourful assembly of people listening to party officials reflecting the “harmonious society” that the Chinese leaders repeatedly advocate.

Hu's slogans have gained urgency in the aftermath of the unprecedented outbreak of violence between the Uighurs and Han Chinese in Xinjiang province recently that left over 180 dead. Not to mention the simmering ethnic tensions in Tibet. And the growing unrest in rural China, which has watched the country's urban coastline transform itself into a veritable Shangri-La while peasants continue to lag behind with their per capita income being less than a third of their relatively affluent metro comrades.

**SHANGHAI'S DAZZLING SKYLINE
AND (BELOW) A MAJOR TRUCK
MANUFACTURING UNIT IN XIAN**



RAJ CHENGAPPA



THE **ULTIMATE STATUS SYMBOL** FOR THE VERY RICH IS THE RED DRAGON

China's filthy rich—and they are plenty of them—are constantly finding new ways to flash their wealth. Ultra-luxury cars or fancy houses are passé. The ultimate status symbol today is having a couple of red-dragon fish swim in your aquarium. They are a highly endangered species and have become a favourite among the wealthy because of their dragon-like looks that resemble China's traditional symbol and the belief that they exude excellent feng shui or harmonising energy. The cost of each fish: 8,00,000 yuan (Rs 57 lakh).

China today is a study in sharp contrasts. Beijing and Shanghai have been transformed into marvels of modern architecture that dazzle the eye and the industrial hubs of Guangzhou and Shenzhen evoke awe and admiration as the new factories of the world. But while sweeping highways now connect most cities and towns in China, change in the hinterland, especially among farmers, is far, far slower. Half of China's rural population still does not have proper drinking water supply. Power supply too is erratic.

Conscious that such wide disparities between urban

and rural areas may result in social unrest and a dangerous peasant rebellion, China's new generation of leaders like Hu and Premier Weng Jiabao have set out on a different kind of Long March—this time to bring peasants into the mainstream of economic progress and quell any potential dissent. With over 700 million people still living in villages and towns across China, it is a humongous task. But as with everything else that it does, the ruling Communist Party of China has given the programme a high-sounding title: The New Socialist Countryside. The goal: to modernise agriculture, develop deep linkages between industry and agriculture, between cities and countryside, and increase rural affluence by doubling its per capita income by 2020.

The showcase for visitors to Xian is Donghan village on the outskirts of the city where money has been pumped in by the Government to build rows of tiled roof cottages with supporting infrastructure such as a cooperative society office, health centre and a cultural complex for farmers to exhibit their paintings. So famous has Donghan